

- COURSE SYLLABUS -

INTRODUCTION TO PHILOSOPHY
DEPARTMENT OF LANGUAGES & CULTURE
32154 - PHIL 1301 – 001
-ONLINE-
MAYMESTER 2025

Dr. Paul R. Shockley
shockleypr@sfasu.edu
www.prshockley.org
Department of Languages and Culture
Office: Dugas Liberal Arts North, 4th floor, office 413.
Virtual Office Hours: By Appointment
Personal appointments are available throughout the week.
Classroom # Ferguson G374

“The unexamined life is not worth living.”
~ Socrates

I. COURSE DESCRIPTION:

In addition to a concern with the goals, nature, and methods of philosophy, Introduction to Philosophy (PHI 1301) course focuses on issues concerning philosophical theories of knowledge and reality, drawing on ideas from a variety of disciplines. Possible topics: the nature of philosophy, the problem of skepticism and knowledge, mind and personal identity, and the nature and existence of God. Emphasis is on the nature of philosophy and its relation to education, logic, and critical thinking.

II. STUDENT LEARNING OUTCOMES

A. Exemplary Educational Objectives:

- Awareness of the scope and variety of texts dealing with various philosophical issues.
- Understanding of the historical and social contexts of philosophical movements.
- Ability to respond critically to works in philosophy.
- Ability to formulate, express and support opinions on the philosophical issues covered in this course.
- Knowledge of cross-cultural influence of philosophy.

“Life can only be understood backwards; but it must be lived forwards.”
~ Soren Kierkegaard

III. GENERAL EDUCATION CORE CURRICULUM

General Education Core Curriculum

The Texas Higher Education Coordinating Board has identified six core learning objectives:

Critical Thinking Skills
 Communication Skills
 Empirical and Quantitative Skills
 Teamwork
 Personal Responsibility
 and Social Responsibility.

SFA is committed to the improvement of its general education core curriculum by regular assessment of student performance on these six objectives.

By enrolling in Introduction to Philosophy you are also enrolling in a Core Curriculum Course that fulfills the critical thinking and personal responsibility requirements:

Core Objective	Definition	How the Core Objective Will be Addressed:
Critical Thinking Skills	To include creative thinking, innovation, inquiry, and analysis, evaluation and synthesis of information.	Sevenfold critical thinking combinationalism (e.g., logical; evidential; existential; pragmatic; viability, explanatory power) and five approaches in critical thinking (e.g., synthetic, analytic, lateral, existential, and prescriptive) employed in two exams. Three out of fifteen online modules dedicated to critical thinking alone Chapters 3-12 from text <i>Thinking with Excellence</i> dedicated to this core requirement as well.
Personal Responsibility	To include the ability to connect choices, actions, and consequences to ethical decision-making.	The core will be met by final essay examination. Reflection Journal and Final Exam are dedicated to critical thinking, ethics and moral reasoning, to existentialism and freedom of choice, and aesthetics as it relates to personal and social responsibility.

IV. REQUIRED & SUGGESTED BOOKS:

The following books will stimulate our thoughts regarding *ultimate questions* like:

- A. Where did we come from? (*origin*)
- B. What are we? Who are we? (*identity*)
- C. Why are we here? (*meaning*)
- D. How should we then live? (*morality*)
- E. What's gone wrong with the world? (*evil*)
- F. What can be done to fix the problems of the world? (*hope*)

REQUIRED:

Paul R. Shockley & Raul F. Prezas, *Thinking with Excellence: Navigating the College Journey & Beyond* (New York: Two Creeks Publishing Group), 2019: ISBN-13: 978-0692194812; ISBN-10: 0692194819). Kindle version (e-version) and softcover is available at Amazon. Softcover is also available at Steen Library in Library Reserves. Be sure to research library reserves hours which may be different than the library hours itself. If you have Kindle Unlimited on Amazon, the book is already included. If you cannot afford this book, contact me privately.

Will Buckingham, et al. *The Big Philosophy Book: Big Ideas Simply Explained* (New York, DK reprint, 2017). ISBN-10: 1465458557; ISBN-13: 978-1465458551. This book is also available in Kindle (e-version), hardcover, and audible (with subscription on Amazon).

If you choose Kindle electronic version for both the cost is around \$19.00 (excluding tax).

SUGGESTED (NOT REQUIRED):

Will Durant, ***The Story of Philosophy: The Lives and Opinions of the World's Greatest Philosophers (Mass Market Paperback)*** 528 pages; Publisher: Pocket Books; 2nd edition (January 1, 1991); ISBN-10: 0671739166. Though not required, it helps orient you to the history of philosophy, offering a contextual understanding of the ideas, movements, and personalities of philosophy.

- A. All books are available on Amazon in print and in e-version. A free printed copy is available in library reserves. Also, *Thinking with Excellence* is free with Amazon Unlimited.
- B. Will Durant's *Story of Philosophy* is also available in both audiobook format and Audio CD. Copies are available in Library Reserves.

"Happiness is the highest good." ~ Aristotle

V. GRADE PROCEDURES, COURSE REQUIREMENTS, & TESTING INFORMATION:

EXAMINATIONS AND GRADE DISTRIBUTION:

I will be evaluating your mastery of the course content in the following ways:

Mid-Term Exam (25%) due by 20 May by 11:59 PM

Final Exam (25%) due by 28 May by 11:59 PM

Personal Reflection Journal (50%) due by 28 May by 11:59 PM

For every assignment, SFA policy for academic integrity will be strictly followed. Please do not plagiarize, cheat, or use AI technology to complete any assignment whatsoever (not even AI tools that edit your grammar and syntax like Grammarly).

ATTENDANCE:

Since this is an online course, you are to engage in D2L online content in real-time, as if you are in actual face-to-face class. Your attendance is based on actively engaging in the D2L content in real-time. If there is no immediate engagement, you may be dropped from the course.

PERSONAL REFLECTION JOURNAL: (50%) DUE TO DROPBOX BY 28 MAY BY 11:59 PM.

You will write 10 philosophical reflections from our course of study. Each reflection should come out of a major topic of study (e.g., Worldview; Plato's Allegory of the Cave; Existentialism; Aesthetics) from Unit 1: Steps 1-8; Unit 2: Steps 1-7 and/or required reading. Thus, no two reflections should be about the same topic covered in the course. Each entry will be at least one page (minimal, no maximum pages), using single-line spacing. Be sure to include a title for each one of your journals to help identify your topic.

For each new entry, begin at the top of each page. 12 size font New Times Roman; 1" margins; first-person. Cite any sources used according to format you know the best, whether that is MLA; APA; Turabian. If you cite sources, embed the sources used in the text or as a footnote or endnote. Bibliography or Works Cited page (if any sources are used) at the end of your complete journal. All entries should be in one document total. No need to upload 10 separate entries. Keep them all in one document.

No use of AI whatsoever to complete any aspect of this journal.

To help you in your reflection journal, use the following questions to write your minimal one-page reflections:

1. What are the key ideas and arguments presented this week, and why are they significant to know?
2. How do these ideas challenge or expand my current understanding of philosophy?
3. Did I encounter any concepts or perspectives that were particularly difficult to grasp? How might I further explore or clarify these concepts and perspectives?
4. Did the content resonate with any personal experiences or beliefs? If so, how and why?

5. How does the philosophy connect with other subjects or fields of knowledge I am interested in?
6. In what ways did the content stimulate critical thinking and intellectual curiosity?
7. Do any ideas or arguments presented in the content have practical implications or applications in my life?
8. What are the potential limitations or critiques of the ideas presented in the content?
9. How can I incorporate the newfound knowledge or perspectives into my academic or personal pursuits?
10. What further questions or topics have emerged from my engagement with the philosophy content I am learning? How can I continue exploring these areas of interest?

Once again, only use these questions to write your reflections. No plagiarism; no use of AI whatsoever. I highly, highly, encourage you to do a daily reflection after finishing a module. I encourage you not to wait till the last day to complete both final exam and reflection journal.

MID-TERM EXAM (25%): 20 May by 11:59 PM

A mid-term online exam will be given with at least 50 questions (e.g., multiple choice; true/false; time-tested). No AI technology is to be used whatsoever in the completion of this exam. SFA policies will be fully enforced.

FINAL EXAM (25%): 28 MAY by 11:59 PM.

A final online exam will be given with at least 50 questions (e.g., multiple choice; true/false; time-tested). No AI technology is to be used whatsoever in the completion of this exam. SFA policies will be fully enforced.

Any late work will be reduced grade level per day without official documentation.

OVERALL CLASS AVERAGE:

If you earn an 89.5+ I will round you up to an A.
If you earn a 79.5+ I will round you up to a B.
If you earn a 69.5+ I will round you up to a C.
If you earn a 59.5+ it is what it is.

LATE WORK:

Your work may be reduced by grade level per day. Official documentation will be needed if essay exams are missed within 24 hours; an email or message alone is insufficient. All essay exam questions are posted around two weeks before they are due. Thus, plan for the unexpected and do not wait till the last moment to do the work. This late policy is taken very seriously. Do not wait till the last moment to do your assignments. Also, do not submit the wrong assignment to do D2L. If done, at least one grade level penalty may be generated.

"If nothing saves us from death, at least love should save us from life." ~ Pablo Neruda

VI. CLASS ATTENDANCE & ENGAGEMENT OF WEEKLY CONTENT

- A. I highly, highly encourage you to actively and qualitatively engage lecture material in an active, consistent way. If you don't attend class and/or simply tab through the material D2L with very little exposure it only affects your comprehension of the material and promotes anxiety.
- B. It is critical you actively engage the course so that you will not be counted as non-attendance and dropped by registrar by 2nd class day which could impact financial aid, scholarships, full-time status, etc.

*"Every word has consequences. Every silence, too."
- Jean-Paul Sartre*

Do you struggle with remembering what you have studied? If given the opportunity, then please read Mortimer J. Adler's *How to Read a Book*. His tactics were life changing for me. Also, consider the following tips developed from well-worn experience:

1. Maintain healthy balance between food, play, & sleep
2. Avoid high sugary snacks, drinks & processed foods
3. Don't allow yourself to be distracted
4. Keep a clean conscience & forgive richly
5. Try to study when you think the best (e.g., morning for morning people)
6. Don't keep doing the same things and hoping for different results.
7. Help each other out; there is a certain strength found in community whereby we can share our strengths to sharpen each other

VII. ADDITIONAL INFORMATION:

- A. D2L Dropbox has all due dates for assignments. Go to "Course Tools" and Look under "Dropbox." Therein you will find clear, step-by-step practical steps and tips to help you
- B. The Final exam will primarily be drawn from Unit 2 modules and topics of study.
- D. **Attendance is expected.** A complete attendance report may be filed with the student's dean and the registrar with the final course grade. *In fact, lack of required engagement online, whether excused or unexcused, means you will receive a final grade of "F" for this course.*
- E. If assignments are altered for exams, students are required to be present for announced exams. Any missed exam without a *cogent documented* excuse will be counted numerically as a zero (00). This is considerably lower than an average F.
- F. Because of the nature of your assignments over assigned readings and lecture material, it is in your *best* interest to engage class content, week, reading material, D2L content, and do the reflection journal in a consistent way.

- G. There could also be additional required readings as deemed appropriate given the topics we are covering. The work you submit for evaluation will only be good as the level of engagement you give to it.
- H. Take good notes, visit your professor, and engage each other.

*"Since it is so likely that children will meet cruel enemies,
let them at least have heard of brave knights and heroic courage." ~ C. S. Lewis*

What is a great question?

Asking questions in class can be very intimidating. We are fearful of being embarrassed or rejected. We don't want to appear "dumb." We push back from the idea of being singled out by the professor whereby we are called upon repeatedly in class; we don't like the spotlight. We don't want to be known as the "teacher's pet."

The situation becomes even more difficult. We come across students who like to argue, who want to be the center of the class, or who redirect your questions in way that benefits them. Out of arrogance, *hubris* (which means excessive pride), and control, they want to claim "superiority" over fellow classmates.

Sadly, we've met educators who don't like to be asked questions. Some are hot-tempered, cynical, and not easy to talk to or even learn from, and deem themselves "god-like" given their background, degrees, and accomplishments. They make us feel irrelevant, uncomfortable, and worthless.

To be sure, many of us don't even know where to begin when it comes to asking good questions. We've never been trained on the science and art of asking good questions. Yet, we want to learn. We want to contribute to class. We want to seize our studies!

"Do one thing every day that scares you." ~ Eleanor Roosevelt

What are we to do?

While there are difficult classes, professors, and classmates, thinking with excellence invites you to ask good questions. Success in life demands good questioning. Most professors we encounter love questions and long for rich classroom dialogue. Outstanding professors, and there are many of them, will also protect you from students who seek to disrupt you, try to take advantage of the classroom setting by showing off, or attempt to "put you down." They want you to learn and will do all they can to facilitate those opportunities. If you can learn how to ask good questions, then you will have a dynamic skill set that will last a lifetime, no matter your career, context, or relationships.

"Before you contradict an old man, my fair friend, you should endeavor to understand him." - Jorge Santayana

We encourage you to think about books, conversations, truth-claims made, and worldviews like a detective by asking clarifying questions like “*What do you mean by that?*” and “*How did you come to that conclusion?*” But here are seven types of questions you should ask when it comes to truth-claims being made by authors, professors, and fellow students:

1. “When you make this truth-claim, are you saying _____?” Here you repeat your understanding of the truth-claim. This is an additional *clarification* question to the two mentioned above.
2. “When you make this truth-claim, would this be an example of what you are trying to say?” Here you give an example of the truth-claim made. This is an *example* question.
3. “If I understand you correctly, your understanding of this truth-claim is _____ [repeat interpretation]? Am I right?” I wonder if the claim could be interpreted this way [give alternative interpretation]?” These are *interpretation* questions.
4. “What are the implications of this truth-claim? ” Or would this be an implication of this truth-claim _____?” You can think about the implications of the truth-claim in how it affects or impacts one’s life, community, context, faith, family, other ideas, history, policy, science, or other types of studies. These are *implication* questions.
5. “Can this truth-claim be true given what we know about _____ [common sense; empirical data; historical facts; philosophical truths; scientific evidence; other realms of studies such as sociology or other inquiries]?” Here we are examining the consistency of the truth-claim with what we already know is true and trustworthy. This is a *consistency* question.
6. “I agree/ disagree with you. Here’s why. I’ve had this experience [state experience; remember to summarize; don’t be too wordy].... What do you think about this experience?” This is an *agreement/disagreement* question rooted in personal experience.
7. “What other ways can we think about this truth-claim that may be foreign to our own particular shared assumptions?” “Would _____ [e.g., different age; culture; gender; race; religion; time; place] interpret this truth-claim the same way?” Here we are using *lateral* type of questioning; we are attempting to think outside of the box.

These seven types of questions, namely, clarification, example, interpretation, implication, consistency, agreement/disagreement, and lateral questions, will benefit you in ways you can never imagine!

“The marvelous thing about a good question is that it shapes our identity as much by the asking as it does by the answering.” ~ David Whyte

VIII. GENERAL EXPECTATIONS, GUIDELINES, & PROCEDURES:
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A. Follow the Five:

1. Know that all university rules governing academic integrity will apply.
2. Lectures may not be taped, recorded, or video transcribed unless for DS Compliance.
3. Respect your classmates and professor.
4. No use of profanity or disrespect.
5. Do not wait till the end of the semester to contact me if you need assistance; I am here for you want you to succeed.

B. Assignments:

The student is responsible for completing assignments in accordance with the specific guidelines identified in the assignment description (in Dropbox).

C. Academic Integrity:

Academic integrity is a responsibility of all university faculty and students. Faculty members promote academic integrity in multiple ways including instruction on the components of academic honesty, as well as abiding by UT university policy for violations. It is student's responsibility to understand every level or category of academic integrity violations (4 levels), possible sanctions imposed for each level, and university policy processes involved. If any violation occurs, I am obligated by university policy to file a report with the Dean of Students; there is no other option for professor.

<https://www.sfasu.edu/sco/about>

Academic integrity violations are categorized into four levels with appropriate sanction guidelines for each.

Level One Violations:

- Reasonable to conclude that the student's behavior was a result of inexperience with academic integrity principles and policies (for example, a first-semester student).
- Violation was minor or occurred on an assignment that was worth a small portion of the student's course grade.

Level Two Violations:

- Actions are dishonest in character.
- Impact a more significant amount of the assignment or course grade.

Level Three Violations:

- Actions are more flagrantly dishonest in character.
- Impact a major or essential portion of the course work.
- Involves planning and deliberation.

Level Four Violations:

- Actions are flagrantly dishonest.
- Serious breaches of profession and personal integrity.

Use of AI in Your Course Work: *No use of generative AI tools permitted in this course whatsoever (stance # 3).*

This course assumes that work submitted by students – all process work, drafts, brainstorming artifacts, final works – will be generated by the students themselves, working individually or in groups as directed by class assignment instructions. This policy indicates the following constitute violations of academic honesty: a student has another person/entity do the work of any substantive portion of a graded assignment for them, which includes purchasing work from a company, hiring a person or company to complete an assignment or exam, and/or using generative AI tools (such as ChatGPT).

Additional notes about the use of generative AI in this course:

AI can help you think but not think for you. It may be a starting point for your thought process, but it is not to do the work for you. In other words, do not enter the discussion post prompt into ChatGPT or other generative AI tools, and copy and paste the response as your answer or substitute words as if it is your work. Said differently, engage with AI responsibly and ethically-which is the lumberjack way. Engage with AI technologies responsibly, critically evaluating AI-generated outputs and considering potential biases, limitations, and ethical implications in your analysis and discussions. Ensure that the data used for AI applications is obtained and shared responsibly. Never pass off as your own work generated by AI. You are 100% responsible for your final product. You are the user; if the AI tool makes a mistake, and you use it, then it's your mistake. If you don't know whether a statement about any item in the output is true, then it is your responsibility to research it. If you cannot verify it as factual, you should delete it. You hold full responsibility for AI-generated content. Ideas must be attributed, and sources must be verified.

Lastly, please know that the rules and practices on use of AI may vary from class to class, discipline to discipline. Do not assume that what is acceptable in a computer science class will be acceptable in this philosophy class. It is your student's responsibility to stay informed as to the instructor's expectations. When in doubt, ask. I earnestly want you to flourish in every possible way in this course and beyond.

D. Free Speech and Class Conduct:

To help improve our critical thinking and writing skills, we will regularly engage in class discussions. The purpose of these discussions will be to recognize that while many of the

students in the class may be on the same level in terms of age or year, there are different abilities in the classroom and different ways to look at issues of academic learning. In other words, one can always learn from one's peers. For this to happen, we must respect one another. Therefore, while I will encourage students to share different opinions and will not stop individuals from disagreeing with one another, I will not allow any student to engage in discriminatory behavior (e.g., age; antisemitism; body; gender; race; religion; sexuality). Also, I will not allow any student to simply try to roll over or silence one's peers. You are in a "safe zone" with me.

E. Acceptable Class Behavior:

Classroom behavior should not interfere with the instructor's ability to conduct the class or the ability of other students to learn from the instructional program (see the Student Conduct Code, policy <http://www.sfasu.edu/policies/student-code-of-conduct-10.4.pdf>). Unacceptable or disruptive behavior will not be tolerated. Students who disrupt the learning environment may be asked to leave class and may be subject to judicial, academic, or other penalties. This prohibition applies to all instructional forums, including electronic, classroom, labs, discussion groups, field trips, etc. The instructor shall have full discretion over what behavior is appropriate/inappropriate in the classroom. There is to be no arguing with me or fellow students; zero tolerance. Toxic behavior will not be allowed in my class. If so, it may result not only in expulsion from class presence but also receive a complete "00" in participation grade.

In the case of this course, disruptive behavior will include the following: consistent use of cell phones/texting during class, consistent participation inside discussions that are not part of classroom dialogue, referring to your teacher or peers in an inappropriate way, physically threatening your teacher or peers, and completing homework assignments for another class. Students participating in such activities can be asked to leave the class and will be counted as absent.

There is absolutely no place for abuse (e.g., bullying; defamation; any form of discrimination; harassment) against each other including your professors. Thus, please know that if these things are committed, Dean of Student's Office and Title IX Office will be informed.

F. Withheld Grades:

Ordinarily, at the discretion of the instructor of record and with the approval of the academic chair/director, a grade of WH will be assigned only if the student cannot complete the course work because of unavoidable circumstances. Students must complete the work within one calendar year from the end of the semester in which they receive a WH, or the grade automatically becomes an F. If students register for the same course in future terms the WH will automatically become an F and will be counted as a repeated course for the purpose of computing the grade point average." For the complete policy, http://www.sfasu.edu/policies/5.5_course-grades.pdf

G. Students with Disabilities:

To obtain disability-related accommodations, alternate formats, and/or auxiliary aids, students with disabilities must contact the Office of Disability Services (ODS), Human Services Building, and Room 325, 4683004 / 468-1004 (TDD) as early as possible in the

semester. Once verified, ODS will notify the course instructor and outline the accommodation and/or auxiliary aids to be provided. Failure to request services promptly may delay your accommodations. For additional information, go to <http://www.sfasu.edu/disabilityservices/>.

H. Mental Health and Wellness:

SFA values students' mental health and the role it plays in academic and overall student success. SFA provides a variety of resources to support students' mental health and wellness. Many of these resources are free, and all of them are confidential.

On-campus Resources:

SFA Counseling Services: www.sfasu.edu/counselingservices
Health and Wellness Hub (corner of E. College and Raguet)
936.468.2401

SFA Human Services Counseling Clinic
www.sfasu.edu/humanservices/139.asp Human Services, Room 202 936.468.1041

Crisis Resources:

Burke 24-hour crisis line: 1.800.392.8343
National Suicide Crisis Prevention: 9-8-8
Suicide Prevention Lifeline: 1.800.273.TALK (8255)
Crisis Text Line: Text HELLO to 741-741

I. Dropped from Class:

Attendance is expected. It is critical that you engage material weekly. If not, then you will be counted as non-attending and will be dropped from class by registrar's office.

J. Caregivers Note:

Parents and caregivers deserve access to education. Especially now, in our virtual learning space, with many children learning from home and schools and unexpected closures, I expect children to be present in class from time to time (Adapted from Dr. Heather Olson Beal). Please consider disclosing your student-caregiver status to me. This is the first step in my being able to accommodate any special needs that arise. While I maintain the same high expectations for all students in my classes, I am happy to problem-solve with you in a way that makes you feel supported as you strive for school-caregiver balance.

IX. HOW TO DO WELL IN THIS COURSE:

Carefully read assigned work. Proactively bombard your assigned readings with the following questions: why, where, what, when, who, and so what?

Consider making an outline of the major units of thought in your readings. As you formulate your outline from the reading, ask yourself the following question: “*What do I see?*” The more observations you make, the better your interpretation of the author’s position or claim may be. Afterwards ask, “*What does it mean?*”

After you outline the author’s position/claim go back and see what arguments are being provided to support that position or claim. Keep asking yourself, “*What is the issue?*” Then consider what objections can be raised against that issue, position, or claim. Lastly, what replies can be given to defend the position or claim?

You should consult with me as often as possible to make sure you understand the material. Do not wait until the day before a test to begin studying. This is not the kind of course for which you can cram and expect to do well.

Consider forming study groups to prepare for exams.

Those who consistently and repeatedly engage the material in real time make higher grades than those who do not.

Make sure you can contact another student for lecture material in case you happen to miss a class (es).

Eight Strategies for First-Rate Studying:

- Read Thoughtfully
- Read Repeatedly
- Read Patiently
- Read Selectively
- Read Imaginatively
- Read Purposefully
- Read Acquisitively
- Read Telescopically

If you want to improve your reading comprehension skills, I encourage you to purchase Mortimer J. Adler’s informative work, *How to Read a Book*.

Please regularly visit with me. Don’t ever hesitate to contact me; I want each of you to succeed with a passion for excellence!

10 MAXIMS FOR ACADEMIC EXCELLENCE:

1. Be focused! Your energy, time, and discipline need to be bent on becoming the very best. Focus on what really counts. Do not allow yourself to become diverted by the trivial and unimportant.
2. Be holistic! Pro-actively make decisions and pursue interests in your daily life that will assist you in obtaining success. Your resources must always be redirected to your goal.
3. Be undivided! Do not separate one are of your life from another. Pursuing opposing interests may marginalize your success because it divides up your energy, time, resources, and attention.
4. Be determined! Academic progress is rough, ever so time-consuming, and ever so demanding. Meet every demand with a determination for excellence. Learn from your mistakes. Pick yourself up when you fail and press on!
5. Be resilient! Do not give up. You will perhaps fail some time or another during your program. You may even become depressed from the critical feedback you receive from your professors and peers. When those times come, and they do for most if not all, you must pick yourself up again-for accomplishing the goal is worth facing seemingly insurmountable obstacles.
6. Be sacrificial! Purposefully let go of those things that will hinder your success. Willfully discard every hindrance and degenerative influence that will keep you from achieving your goal with a passion for excellence. Routinely examine your life and see what is encouraging or discouraging you from reaching excellence.
7. Be healthy! Realize, as Aristotle states, that one area of your life impacts all other areas, whether intellectual, physical, or moral. Take very tender care of your mind, soul, and body. You need to strive to be holistically healthy-for if you are not mentally, physically, and spiritually healthy, then you may easily become fatigued, develop inner angst, regret, disappointment, and waiver in the completion of your goals. Remember, a good night sleep is one of the best things you can do for yourself.
8. Be supported! Cultivate a network of people who will exhort you to succeed! Develop relationships with peers who are also bent on achieving success.
9. Be excellent! Successful students realize the importance of cultivating a disposition, i.e., an inner character, which desires intellectual and moral excellence. Seek to desire excellence. Aristotle encourages us to do deeds of excellence until excellence becomes habitual in our personhood.
10. Be balanced! Learn how to balance “having fun” with “hard work.” Don’t ignore those opportunities to relax or play hard. In fact, pursue them! But do not allow those opportunities to displace your study opportunities. Remember, learning is pleasurable!

One of the dangers for those who do achieve success is the problem of malnourishment. Successful people may reach their long-term goals, but so many of them starve themselves in the process. Do not so focus on your goals that you miss out on dynamic opportunities that can nourish your person, inform your circumstance, grow your character, and enlarge your world. In other words, do not so focus on the future that you neglect the blessings that are right in front of you.

*“Since we cannot know all that there is to be known about everything,
we ought to know a little about everything.” ~ Blaise Pascal*

THE PROBLEM OF PERFECTIONISM:

*~“Perfectionism is self-destructive simply because there’s no such thing as perfect. Perfection is an unattainable goal.” ~ Brené Brown, **The Gifts of Imperfection***

For some of us we feel like we are failures because we didn’t achieve a perfect score, a perfect GPA, or are perfect ourselves. The problem of perfectionism is a painful vice, unattainable, and an empty promise.

Here are 10 alternative goals you could consider instead:

1. Bring yourself, exactly as you are, to everything you do as a philosopher. Start now as a student. No one will be able to be a philosopher the exact way that you are.
2. Ask questions when you don’t know something. We all know you’re here to learn and that the information is new, complex, and sometimes overwhelming. The best philosophers ask questions and never stop. Being open to feedback will be a key to success here.
3. Fully invest in being a lifelong learner. View this academic journey as the beginning of your learning journey. Things will change, new research will emerge, new policies will be adopted, you will move, meet new people, be presented you with new challenges, new settings, and new experiences. Your life structure will change – and you will be much better prepared to handle these things if you are a life-long learner.
4. Be okay with not knowing. Everybody feels this way about certain ways and at certain times. No one is immune. See #2 and #3 above for strategies to deal with this.
5. Adopt a philosophy akin to Maya Angelou’s “do the best you can. Then when you know better, do better”.
6. Anticipate, meet, and exceed the needs of others in your spheres of influence.
7. Accept that your best work won’t always result in the outcome that you’re looking for. That doesn’t mean it wasn’t your best work and that doesn’t mean you should stop pushing to improve.
8. Work on becoming a really good listener; it pays dividends.
9. Prioritize your mental health over everything else. Be kind to yourself. Give yourself grace.

~ Adapted from **Brené Brown, *The Gifts of Imperfection***

*“We do not learn from experience... we learn from reflecting on experience.”
– John Dewey*

X. CLASS SCHEDULE, DAILY TOPICS, & ASSIGNED READING:

"Each of these philosophers has some lesson for us, if we approach him [philosophy] properly. 'Do you know,' asks Emerson, 'the secret of the true scholar? In every man [person] there is something wherein I may learn of him [one]; and in that I am his [one's] pupil.'" ~ Will Durant, The Story of Philosophy, xxix

- A. Depending upon class context, I may alter our readings, topics, and assignments. Notwithstanding, follow this outline unless otherwise directed by professor. Sometimes I may ask you to re-read certain chapters or portions from a variety of articles.
- B. **Tutorials, topics, central questions, and reading assignments (The following tutorials will be paralleled to units on D2L):**

Tutorials	Topics	Central questions & key themes in units 1 & 2 content	Reading Assignment:
May 12	Welcome to Philosophy & YOUR WORLDVIEW	What is Philosophy? What is your worldview?	Read "Overview" in Course Content Read Syllabus Read <i>Thinking with Excellence</i> , chapters 3-8; 11. Optional but encouraged: Unit 1: Introduction: "Welcome to Philosophy." Begin reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on the section: <i>The Ancient World</i>
May 13	Starting Point for doing philosophy! Worldview Reflection Assignment	Complete the Worldview Reflective Assignment	Read <i>Thinking with Excellence</i> , chapters 3-8; 11 & 12. Optional: Unit 1: Steps 1-2 (from D2L course content) Continue reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on section: <i>The Ancient World</i> .
May 14		<i>The Origins of Greek Philosophy</i>	Optional: Unit 1: Step 3 (from D2L course content)

	What is Philosophy? How did Philosophy Begin?		Continue reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on section: <i>The Ancient World</i> .
May 15	Socrates, Plato, & Aristotle	The origins of Greek Philosophy	Optional: Unit 1: Step 3. Finish reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on section: <i>The Ancient World</i> .
May 16	Post-Aristotelian & Medieval Philosophy: Focus on St. Augustine & St. Thomas Aquinas	The integration of Philosophy & Theology	Optional: Unit 1: Step 4. Continue reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on second section: <i>The Medieval World</i>
May 17	Two areas of focus: We conclude our examination into Medieval philosophy by considering the Jewish philosophy of Maimonides New Topic: Rise of Modern Philosophy: Rene Descartes	<i>"I Think, therefore I am."</i>	Optional: Unit 1: Step 5. Finish reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on second section: <i>The Medieval World</i>
May 18	Modern Philosophy & Epistemology	<i>Modern Empiricism vs. Modern Rationalism</i>	Unit 1: Step 6 Begin reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on third section: <i>Renaissance and the Age of Reason</i>
May 19	Modern Philosophy Continues	<i>Skepticism vs. Scottish Common Sense Realism</i>	Unit 1: Step 7: Continue reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on third section: <i>Renaissance and the Age of Reason</i>

May 20 Unit 2:	American Philosophy, Continental Philosophy, & Introduction to Ethics: CONGRATULATIONS	<i>If something works, does it make it true?</i>	Unit 1: Step 8 Finish reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on third section: <i>Renaissance and the Age of Reason</i> Begin Unit 2: Begin reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on fourth section: <i>The Age of Revolution</i>
May 21	Introduction to Ethics		Unit 2 online material begins, step 1. Continue reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on fourth section: <i>The Age of Revolution</i>
May 22	Continued Ethics		Unit 2: Step 2: Begin reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on fifth section: <i>The Modern World</i>
May 23	Environmental Philosophy & More		Unit 2: Step 3
May 24	Introduction to Philosophy of Religion: Western Thought	The question of God	Finish reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on fifth section: <i>The Modern World</i>

			Unit 2: Step 4
May 25	Philosophy of Religion: Eastern Thought:	What are the contributions made by Eastern Thought? What is evil? What is a miracle?	Unit 2: Step 5 Begin reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on sixth section: <i>The Contemporary World</i>
May 26	Philosophical Aesthetics?	<i>What is art vs. non-art? If there is a difference, how?</i>	finish reading <i>The Philosophy Book</i> with focus on sixth section: <i>The Contemporary World</i> Unit 2: Step 6 Please re-read chapter 11, <i>Thinking with Excellence</i>
May 28:	You finished both Units! Completed reflection journal is due by 11:59 PM	<i>#Golumberjacks!</i>	FINAL EXAM: May 28 by 11:59 PM REFLECTION JOURNAL IS DUE by 11:59 PM.

"When you look into an abyss, the abyss also looks into you."
~Friedrich Nietzsche

XI. OTHER POLICY INFORMATION:

PHIL: 1301: Typically meets three times each week (Monday/Wednesday/Friday) in 50-minute segments for 16 weeks and meets for a 2.5-hour final examination. Students have significant weekly reading assignments, and typically complete mid-term exam, a final exam, and reflection journal. These activities average a minimum of 6 hours of work per week to prepare outside of classroom hours. Online (and hybrid) version of Introduction to Philosophy contains extensive reading and written content which includes the same information students in a face-to-face lecture course receive. Students engage in online modules for at least six hours per week. For every hour engaging with content, students spend at least two hours completing associated activities and assessments.

"It is the mark of an educated mind to be able to entertain a thought without accepting it." – Aristotle, Metaphysics

XII. GRADING RUBRIC:

Here's the rubric I use to book reports, essays, analyses, creative projects, and research papers. A separate grading rubric is being designed for AI Assignment.

"Almost all our suffering is the product of our thoughts. We spend nearly every moment of our lives lost in thought, and hostage to the character of those thoughts. You can break this spell, but it takes training just like it takes training to defend yourself..." ~ Sam Harris

Here's the rubric I use to critique your assignments (excluding mid-term if objective questions):

An excellent book report, essay, research paper, discussion post, or any other assignment (A) meets or exceeds all of these criteria for both content and writing:

Content

- Demonstrates originality of thought, creativity, and particular insight into the subject
- Demonstrates excellent and thorough understanding of the material
- Uses primary and secondary sources in a way that demonstrates high level of intellectual engagement with the text
- Uses primary and secondary sources in such a way that demonstrates the ability to independently research, read, and assimilate material relevant to the topic and to include it in the paper in a useful and insightful way
- Demonstrates the ability to read texts from different perspectives, traditions, cultures, and time periods with nuance and sensitivity, understanding how context affects interpretation.
- Logical fallacies are completely avoided.
- Truth claims are cogently justified (e.g., logical reasoning; empirical evidence)

Writing

- Includes excellent writing that is interesting to read, clear, correct, polished, varied, and appropriate to the nature of the audience and goal
- Demonstrates completely correct handling of the mechanics of citation, attribution, and integration of quoted and paraphrased material
- Is well organized, with a choice of writing and paragraph structure that guides readers through the work in a way that is well suited to the specific aims, audience, and tone of the goals of assignment.
- Is copy-edited and polished at the sentence level to within an inch of its life.

Excellent, thorough, appropriate integration of course lectures and required readings integrated into work. Use of quotes, paraphrases, and references used with full documented integrity.

A good paper (B) meets or exceeds all of these criteria for both content and writing:

Content

- Demonstrates a good understanding of the material
- Uses primary and secondary sources in a way that demonstrates a high level of intellectual engagement with the text
- Demonstrates the ability to read texts from different perspectives, traditions, cultures, and time periods, with an understanding of how context affects interpretation
- Logical fallacies are avoided.
- Truth claims are justified with good argumentation.

Writing

- Includes good-quality paper that is interesting to read, clear, correct, and appropriate to the nature of the assignment's goal
- Demonstrates correct handling of the mechanics of citation, attribution, and integration of quoted and paraphrased material
- Is well organized at the outline and paragraph level
- Is carefully copy-edited and almost entirely error-free

Good and appropriate use of course lectures and required readings integrated into your work (footnotes; endnotes). Use of quotes, paraphrases, and references used with full integrity.

An average quality paper (C) meets all of these criteria for both content and writing:

Content

- Demonstrates solid understanding of the material; may sometimes not show full understanding of how sources relate to other material in the course
- Uses primary and secondary sources in a way that demonstrates intellectual engagement with the text at a level appropriate to undergraduate students
- May not demonstrate initiative in research; may sometimes show a superficial understanding of the texts
- Demonstrates the ability to read texts from different perspectives, traditions, cultures, and time periods with comprehension, but may have difficulty in not reading the text from an exclusively modern- or culture-specific position
- Logical fallacies are slightly evidenced.
- Truth claims are insufficiently justified (not argued very well)

Writing

- Includes average-quality writing that is correct and appropriate to the nature of the assignment's audience and goal
- Demonstrates an average handling of the mechanics of citation, attribution, and integration of quoted and paraphrased material; may be awkward in integration and attribution of sources
- Somewhat organized at the outline and paragraph level; may be unfocused or somewhat not organized in the most effective order
- Is satisfactorily copy-edited, although some problems of language may remain.

Average use of quotes, paraphrases, and references used with full integrity. Average use and integration of course lectures and required readings in your work (footnotes; endnotes). Use of quotes, paraphrases, and references used with full integrity.

An average (D or below):

Includes any one of these problems to a noticeable extent:

Content

- Demonstrates a deficient understanding of the material
- Does not engage with primary and secondary sources, or does so in a superficial, proof-texting way
- Includes difficulty in comprehending or engaging with texts from different perspectives, traditions, cultures, and time periods
- Logical fallacies are discovered.
- Truth-claims are not justified or are poorly justified.

Writing

- Includes writing that is not appropriate to the nature of the assignment's audience and goal (e.g., too casual, or too jargonistic)
- Includes persistent problems with the mechanics of citation, attribution, and integration of quoted and paraphrased material
- Lacks organization at the outline and paragraph level
- Includes persistent and/or systemic problems at the sentence level (structure of sentences; appropriate word choice; spelling and punctuation; other grammar issues; general clarity)

Poor, anemic use and lack of consistent integration of course lectures and required readings in your work (footnotes; endnotes). Poor, fuzzy, minimal, or no use of quotes, paraphrases, and references used with full integrity. F for those not referencing material with full integrity.

